

Three Reasons to Learn Relative Adverbs

From VOA Learning English, this is Everyday Grammar.

In an earlier program, we talked about the relative pronouns *who*, *that*, and *which*. We promised to give you more details about how to use relative clauses. In this episode, we look at how the **relative adverbs** *where*, *when*, and *why* are used.

Let's take a look at how relative adverbs work. An adverb is a word that describes a verb, an adjective, another adverb or a sentence. It is often used to show time, manner and place, or degree. The relative pronouns *where*, *when*, and *why* act as adverbs when they join sentences or clauses. Take these two sentences:

This is a swimming pool.
I used to swim in the pool.

Notice how you can put the sentences together with the word *where*:

This is the pool *where* I used to swim.

Another way to say that is "This is the pool *in which* I used to swim." That is a formal way and is usually only found in writing. We use the relative adverb *where* to show the place of an action.

The relative adverb *when* tells about the time of an action. Let's look at an example from [The Logical Song](#) by the rock group Supertramp.

*When I was young, it seemed that life was so wonderful,
A miracle, oh it was beautiful, magical.*

...

*And they showed me a world where I could be so **dependable**,
Clinical, intellectual, cynical.*

The singer says that life was wonderful *when* he was young. Later, he uses another adverb to show the world *where* he could be dependable. A more formal way to say that would be "They showed me a world *in which* I could be dependable."

We often want to tell the reason for an action. This week, President Obama visited Alaska ([see our article on his hike up a glacier](#)) and talked about **melting** ice. So much ice is melting in Alaska, he said, that sea levels are rising quickly. Here's how he put it:

"The pace of melting is only getting faster. It's now twice what it was between 1950 and 2000 -- twice as fast as it was just a little over a decade ago. And it's one of the reasons *why* sea levels rose by about eight inches over the last century, and *why* they're **projected** to rise another one to four feet this century."

President Obama made one sentence from these two ideas:

Ice is melting very quickly.
Sea levels rose about eight inches in the last 100 years.

His speech has another clause with a relative adverb that combines these ideas:

Ice is melting very quickly.
Scientists predict that sea levels will rise even more.

The words "the reason" or "the reasons" often appear before the relative adverb *why*, but sometimes they are left out, as in President Obama's speech: "... and *why* they're projected to rise another one to four feet this century."

Are you ready to try some sentences on your own? Put together these sentences with relative adverbs:

The coffeehouse is in my neighborhood.
He got a job in a coffeehouse.

Is your answer like this?

The coffeehouse *where* he got a job is in my neighborhood.

Here's another one:

I got home from work.
I saw the dogs playing in the yard.

One way to put these ideas together is,

I saw the dogs playing in the yard when I got home from work.

Finally, let's put these two sentences together.

The dogs frightened the cat.
The cat ran up the tree.

Combine these ideas as:

The dogs are the reason why the cat ran up the tree.

You will sometimes hear *that* instead of *why* after the word *reason* as in,

The dogs are the reason that the cat ran up the tree.

We leave you with Earth Wind and Fire singing *Reasons*

*I can't find the reasons
But my love for you it won't disappear
Can't find the reasons, why I love you, my baby*

I'm Jill Robbins.

And I'm Jonathan Evans.

Dr. Jill Robbins wrote this story for Learning English. George Grow was the editor.

Words in This Story

adverb – *n.* a word that describes a verb, an adjective, another adverb, or a sentence and that is often used to show time, manner, place, or degree

dependable – *adj.* able to be trusted to do or provide what is needed; able to be depended on

melt – *v.* to change or to cause (something) to change from a solid to a liquid usually because of heat

project – *v.* to plan, calculate, or estimate (something) for a time in the future

Now it's your turn. Write a sentence with a relative adverb and we'll give you feedback in the comments section. And let us know what you think of the new video quiz for Everyday Grammar. See the left column above for the quiz.